

zines like *Digit*, consumers have learnt more about technology, and are generally more interested in it than ever before. Manufacturers have kept pace with the consumer, offering multiple solutions and products to please the consumers' new-found fancies. You read about a technology because you want to, then you see an advertisement, you see the falling prices, and you want to buy it. The age-old system; the twist is, you now are a much more discerning buyer. It's the same old circle of product-life; you just know more about the birds and the bees now.

Producer/Consumer

Alvin Toffler, noted futurist and author, first used the word "prosumer" in his book *The Third Wave* back in 1980. He predicted that with the burgeoning number of producers/manufacturers, markets would be inundated with options for us end users. Once this reached saturation point, the only way forward would be to give the end user exactly what he wanted. His definition of "prosumer" was the amalgamation of producer and consumer. He referred to it this way:

"...the rise of the prosumer. Third Wave civilization brings with it the re-emergence of a huge economic sector based on production for use rather than for exchange, a sector based on do-it-for-yourself rather than do-it-for-the-market. This dramatic turn-about, after 300 years of "marketization," will both demand and make possible radically fresh thinking about all our economic problems, from unemployment and welfare to leisure and the role of work."

Toffler thus predicted that the lines between consumer and producer would blur, that producers would make simple, standard products, and allow the consumer to choose what to add and what to subtract to make for ultimate personalisation. A lot of people continue to see such ideas as absurd, considering the costs that manufacturers would have to incur in order to make customised products; however, we already see working examples in our lives today.

You And Your Tech

Consider the PC market. Once upon a time, less than five years ago, if you wanted to pick and choose components to build a system, your local assembler was the only way to go—branded PCs were way too expensive. Today,

most big PC brands allow you to customise almost every component of your system. Take Dell for example; all you have to do is pick a base system, starting from a processor-motherboard combination, and then choose what else you want to add to it. You get to choose.

How come? Well, in order to break the local assembler's stranglehold on the market, big corporations had to submit to the whims and fancies of the professional consumer.

We see this happening universally, for all technology sectors: after all, why shouldn't individual customers get customised solutions? We want to be able to choose our cell phone talk plan, the amount of RAM in our systems, the texture of the seats in our cars, the toppings on our pizzas, the TV channels we don't want, the capacity of our iPods, whether or not our Xboxes should have hard drives, the strap colour on our swatches, the bezel for our phones... you get the drift.

It Doesn't End Here

More than hardware, software is being targeted at the prosumer. The entire open source movement could be considered prosumer-friendly. Don't like a feature? Just get rid of it! And it's not just open source and Linux developers that are promoting prosumerism: Microsoft released XNA Game Studio Express in the second-half of 2006. This development tool will allow novices and amateur game developers to create games for Windows as well as for the Xbox 360. Although users need to pay \$99 (Rs 4,300) per year to be able to test games on the 360s, Windows development is free. So this means that anyone who's played a game and thought, "This sucks, I'm sure I can build a better game..." will have to put their money where their mouths are and prove it.

The current trend of providing end users with heaps upon heaps of choices just to ensure that everyone's interested does seem doomed when you look at the advantages that a true prosumer industry would have. However, it's not about to happen overnight.

The desire to customise has even prompted us to provide you with various DIY (Do-It-Yourself) workshops in this issue. A few of these are alternatives to commercially available products, and built for your needs. Are we looking at a global adoption of the Nike slogan? Wait and watch, our Sixth Sense tells us. ☒

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